

“All the News
That’s Fit to Print”

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, sunny, breezy, northwest winds will average 10 to 20 miles per hour, high 61. **Tonight**, clear, dry, low 48. **Tomorrow**, sunny, dry, warmer, high 71. Weather map, Page 26.

VOL. CLXXV ... No. 60,873

© 2026 The New York Times Company

SUNDAY, MAY 3, 2026

Prices in Canada may be higher

\$6.00



ERIN SCHAFF/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Brad Watson watching cows leave the milking parlor at his dairy farm, Butter Ridge, after an auction in April.

THE LAST DAYS OF BUTTER RIDGE

By ELI SASLOW

COLUMBIA CROSS ROADS, Pa. — Brad Watson, 41, awoke without an alarm at 5:30 a.m., strapped on his headlamp and headed to the barn. Cold air leaked through a small gap in the boards, and he stuffed a paper bag into the hole to block the wind. He knew every detail of the barn in the morning: hay shifting beneath his boots, heat rising off the cows, the way the milking equipment froze against his hands. He walked through the stalls to greet each cow by name and then stopped.

It was Meg, a purebred cow, one of his best. She had flipped over her stall in the night and twisted in her chain, strangling to death. He knelt to touch her head and then kept walking toward the milking

The Watsons Milked Cows for Generations. Now, Another Dairy Farm Is Gone.

parlor. More than 90 other cows still needed to be milked, twice a day, every day, and that work never stopped for a weekend, or a vacation, or a dead cow, or any other crisis during a winter in which his family dairy business was beginning to unravel.

He guided the cows into the parlor one at a time, patting their flanks to help them stay calm. “Come on, girls. Settle down,” he said. He hooked each one to a

machine and watched the milk start to flow as he ran through the numbers again in his head. His milk check came every other week, and it never covered his bills. Feed, fuel and fertilizer had nearly doubled in recent months. Lately, he was losing several hundred dollars each day, and without Meg the math would be worse.

Brad attached the next cow to the machine and texted his father, Brian Watson, 62.

“I can’t keep going like this,” Brad told him. “I could make more by picking cans up off the road. I’m done.”

“Don’t think you failed,” Brian replied. “You’re the last Watson milking.”

The Watsons had been dairy farming in the rolling hills of northern Pennsylvana-

Continued on Page 16

Voting Ruling Could Incite Endless Redistricting Wars

Fair Representation and Power of Voters Are Probable Casualties in Hail of Maps

By NICK CORASANITI

The Supreme Court’s decision to upend a key provision of the Voting Rights Act has plunged the nation into a dizzying new era of partisan conflict, most likely ushering in a forever redistricting war that could produce fewer competitive seats in Congress and further polarize American politics.

Left as probable casualties are longstanding principles of fair representation — along with American voters, who are likelier now to be shunted into hyperpartisan districts drawn in each state to benefit the party in power. A great carving could effectively dilute the power of millions, especially minority voters, and make partisan primaries more important than general elections when it comes to choosing leaders.

“We lost one of the last seatbelts of our democracy,” said Alanah Odoms, executive director of the American Civil Liberties Union of Louisiana.

The ruling by the court’s conservative majority struck down

Louisiana’s congressional map, describing it as an unconstitutional gerrymander that improperly considered race to create a majority-Black district. The ruling, Democrats argued, effectively removed one of the final guardrails that kept the most ruthlessly partisan interests at bay when it came to drawing congressional and legislative maps.

Some also fear that the court’s decision will reverberate beyond the halls of Congress.

“Judges, school board members, councilmen — doesn’t matter, it will affect them all,” Press Robinson, a Louisiana resident who pushed for more minority representation in the state’s congressional maps, said on Wednesday.

More broadly, minority voters fear a backslide after losing what they say was a critical legal protection.

“Black Americans have never been fully represented in the electoral process,” said Damon Hew-

Continued on Page 21

TIMELINE A look at the key events that led to the passage of the Voting Rights Act of 1965 and how it has been used in recent decades. PAGE 22

THE LONG GAME Since his days as a lawyer and in his first years as a judge, the chief justice has aimed to limit the Voting Rights Act. PAGE 21

In Primaries, Trump Targets The ‘Disloyal’

By SHANE GOLDMACHER

President Trump has spent the past year using the federal government to target those he considers his political enemies. Now, in a series of primaries this month, he is turning his ire on fellow Republicans by asking voters to punish those who have crossed him.

Contests in Indiana, Louisiana and Kentucky in the coming weeks all feature Trump-backed challengers trying to oust Republican incumbents who have earned Mr. Trump’s anger. The fights have soaked up energy and cash from the president’s allies and his political operation, pulling attention away from the broader battle with Democrats over control of Congress this fall.

In Indiana, Mr. Trump hopes to oust a half-dozen Republican state senators who defied him by defeating a redistricting effort that would have drawn the state’s two Democratic House members out of power. In Louisiana, he is backing a challenger to a Republican senator, Bill Cassidy, who voted to convict him in his second impeachment trial after the Jan. 6, 2021, Capitol riot. In Georgia, Mr. Trump is supporting a candidate for governor who is running against the Republican secretary of state, Brad Raffensperger, who refused to help the president “find” votes for him in the after-

Continued on Page 20

Spirit, Pioneer Of Cheap Fares, Ceases Flying

By NIRAJ CHOKSHI

Spirit Airlines reshaped aviation in the United States by stripping down flying to its essentials and selling what were often the cheapest tickets around. But the airline shut down for good on Saturday, a victim of the rising costs it once excelled at controlling.

In a statement just after 2 a.m., Spirit said it had canceled all flights and told passengers not to go to the airport. On the airline’s homepage, a bright yellow banner declared that the airline was “winding down all operations.”

The budget airline had lost billions of dollars in recent years as it struggled with intense competition at its most important airports — Las Vegas, Florida and New York among them — along with rising labor costs and aircraft maintenance needs.

As a result, Spirit filed for bankruptcy in 2024 and again in 2025. It had aimed to emerge from the second bankruptcy this summer as a smaller company, but those plans fell apart as jet fuel prices rose dramatically in recent weeks, a consequence of the U.S. and Israeli war with Iran.

The Trump administration started an 11th-hour effort to provide Spirit a \$500 million lifeline, but government officials and the airline’s creditors could not reach a deal in time to save the company.

Continued on Page 24

A.I. Prompting Writing Revival In Classrooms

By DANA GOLDSTEIN

LEWISBORO, N.Y. — For today’s high school and college students, the all-night writing session, hunched over a laptop at home or in a library carrel, is on the way out.

In the era of artificial intelligence, take-home writing assignments have become so difficult to police for integrity that many educators have simply stopped assigning them.

Instead, in a rapid shift, teachers are requiring students to write inside the classroom, where they can be observed. Assignments have changed too, with some educators prompting students to reflect on their personal reactions to what they’ve learned and read — the type of writing that A.I. struggles to credibly produce.

This transformation is happening across the educational landscape, from suburban districts and urban charter schools to community colleges and the Ivy League.

The New York Times heard from nearly 400 college and high school educators who responded to a callout about how generative A.I. is changing writing instruction. Almost all described a deep rethinking of how to teach writing — and whether it still matters, since A.I. has become a better writer than most students (and adults), they said.

Teachers are responding to a widespread challenge. Over the past year, A.I. use has become

Continued on Page 19



JEFF ROBERSON/ASSOCIATED PRESS

Breakthrough in the Kentucky Derby

Golden Tempo is the first winner to be trained by a woman. Coverage at nytimes.com/athletic.

Swalwell Built a Career on Social Media. His Accusers Used It to Warn Others.

By MADISON MALONE KIRCHER

Eric Swalwell was once hailed as “the Snapchat king of Congress” for his prolific use of the app with disappearing messages.

Mr. Swalwell had developed a reputation as a digital native, a person who seemed to have a deep understanding of how to harness the power of social media.

In the end, social media would play a critical role in his undoing.

It was on social media where early whispers of sexual misconduct accusations against Mr. Swalwell swirled after he entered the California governor’s race last year. After hearing similar chatter and allegations directly from women, two Democratic influencers built a network using some of the same platforms that his accusers said he had used to connect with them.

Cheyenne Hunt, one of the influencers, said she connected some

Network Grew Around Multiple Allegations

of the accusers with one another. She also told the former aide who eventually alleged in news reports that Mr. Swalwell had sexually assaulted her in a New York hotel that other women were preparing to come forward. The con-

tent creators later used social media to collect stories from the women and generate interest online.

On April 10, The San Francisco Chronicle and CNN published the detailed accounts that ultimately ended Mr. Swalwell’s political career after interviewing the accusers for weeks and working to try to verify their allegations.

Mr. Swalwell has denied he committed any sexual misconduct.

Mr. Swalwell entered the governor’s race in November, hoping to capitalize on his national image as a Democratic attack dog and his ability to reach voters on social media. He invited several influencers to a kickoff meeting on Zoom last year, recognizing their power in the modern era.

Among the content creators Mr. Swalwell won over was Arielle Fodor, known online as “Mrs.

Continued on Page 14

INTERNATIONAL 4-12

U.S. Colleges Lose Luster

In France, worries about visas, academic freedom and safety are making schools like Sciences Po in Paris more attractive to students. PAGE 4

Venezuela’s Problems Persist

President Trump says he will “unleash prosperity” with oil. Many in Caracas say it’ll take far more than that. PAGE 6

NATIONAL 13-24

Access to Abortion Pill

A federal appeals court temporarily halted a regulation that expanded access to mifepristone. PAGE 24



METROPOLITAN

ICE Has an Edge Here

Agents benefit from Long Island politicians’ aid, even as some in the community warn of their presence. PAGE 1

Gunfire Sets Off Protests

In the mountains of northern New York, many residents are wary of the prospect of a howitzer range. PAGE 1

SPECIAL SECTION

Planning for a Longer Life

How far will your money take you? Living longer is raising fresh questions about quality, affordability and the best strategies for making savings last.

ARTS & LEISURE

Reasons to Look Their Best

The stars and the director of “The Devil Wears Prada 2” talk about their work and lives, and what the film taught them about being a boss. PAGE 10

SUNDAY OPINION

Jasmine Sun

PAGE 6



THE MAGAZINE

Greatest Living Songwriters

Music insiders and critics weigh in on artists like Taylor Swift who are defining the new American songbook.

SUNDAY BUSINESS

Eavesdropping on Tech’s Elite

Dwarkanish Patel’s podcast has become mandatory listening among artificial intelligence builders, backers and workers. His podcast averages two million listens per episode. PAGE 6

Oil Prices Hit Even Bathhouses

High fuel costs caused by the war in Iran are imperiling the Japanese sento, a tradition for nearly a millennium that remains a social lifeline for the country’s isolated older population. PAGE 1

